

◀ GREAT HELM

Date c.1350

Origin England

Material Steel

The great helm covered the whole face and head and became common in the 12th century. It was made with three plates of steel, with a pointed crown and rounded skull to deflect blows, and had only narrow slots for vision.

Rounded skull



◀ BARBUTE

Date c.1445

Origin Italy

Material Steel

The barbute had a pointed top and rounded cheekpieces, but no visor, which left a small opening for the face. This example is known as a "Corinthian barbute" for its similarity to classical Greek helmets.



Y-shaped opening for face

Brass borders decorated with "wriggled" cable pattern

Ventilation holes called "breaths"

Conical visor

◀ BASINET AND AVENTAIL

Date 1350–1400

Origin Northern Italy

Material Steel

Basinets were introduced in the 14th century. They were often egg-shaped, with a pointed top. The aventail or mail collar had a leather band with holes. This band fitted onto the brass verrelles that bordered the helmet's rim.

▶ JOUSTING HELM

Date 15th century

Origin Europe

Material Steel

This "frog-mouthed" jousting helm had a steel skull piece and another piece of steel wrapped around the head. It was a simple construction, but offered good protection from lance-thrusts to the face.

Narrow sights



▲ HOUNSKULL BASINET

Date 1350–1400

Origin Italy

Material Steel

This hounskull basinet – its name a corruption of the German *Hundsgugel* ("dog head"), from its pointed visor – has the typical aventail or mail collar to protect the wearer's neck and shoulders.

